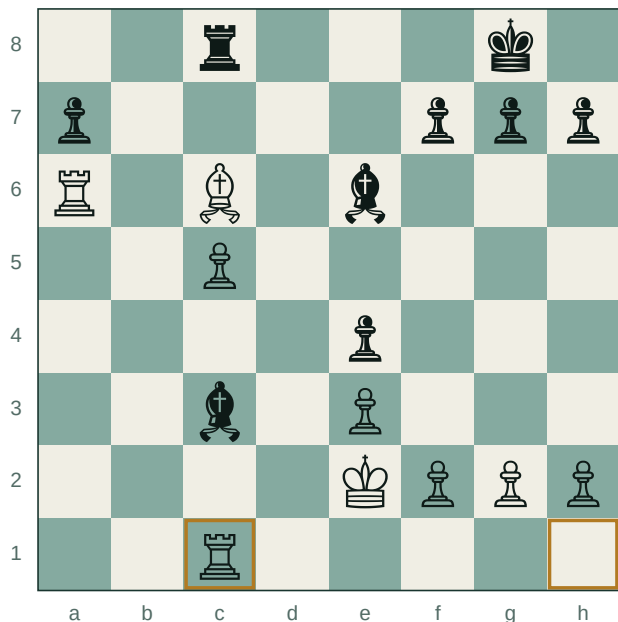


Capture the defender: Black, move 26

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Rc1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Bc4+ 27. Kd1 Bxa6 28. Rxc3 Rxc6

26...Bc4+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From c4 it attacks king on e2 and rook on a6. Recorded reply: **27.Kd1**.

27...Bxa6 The bishop captures the rook on a6. Recorded reply: **28.Rxc3**.

28...Rxc6 The rook captures the bishop on c6.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -2 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e2. Geometrically undefended: rook on a6 and rook on c1. Check for tactical protection.